Bhagwati. "What he (Darshan) has written is a completely reckless character assassination and there is no iota of truth in his statements," they wrote in a no-nonsense warning shot. "He has harmed our reputation and we reserve our rights to prosecute him for spreading malicious statements against us thereby impacting our reputation." Sucheta Dalal, the redoubtable journalist who exposed the 1992 stock market scam, tweeted her displeasure thus: "This is completely stupefying—I do not know @MahuaMoitra personally at all—I may have retweeted some of her stuff. I don't know Pallavi Shroff and I used to know #ShardulShroff long ago. I dare anyone to find any links between me and them.... This is one time the govt ought to help prevent this kind of slander by some crooks!!" And Pinaki, four-time MP and senior advocate at the Supreme Court, threatened to sue the Odisha BJP. The strong blowback suggested there were holes in the affidavit. By the time Darshan appeared on TV, it seemed like a qualified retreat to the basic plan: Get Mahua.

STORMY PETREL

Originally from Cachar, the sliver of Bengali demography in Assam, Mahua has spun a few stories around her early interest in politics. One had her sending an aerogram to her parents while still a diligent Mathematics and Economics student—and evidently also a dreamer—from somewhere under the spires of Mount Holyoake in Massachusetts, talking of a desire to take to public life in India after a few years working in the US. In multiple interviews, she has also spoken of the 10th reunion of her batch there where, seeing the throng of fellow investment bankers around her, she suddenly felt the urge to turn a new leaf. At any rate, in the 11th year of a smooth career, she quit as vice-president at JP Morgan Chase, London, heeded her inner calling and took the plunge.

First consorting with the Congress, a spell during which she enjoyed proximity with Rahul Gandhi, she switched to the TMC a year later. A ticket and an assembly poll victory from Nadia's Karimpur came in 2016; the Lok Sabha's gates opened in 2019. Those are the gates that may now clang shut on her. Her bristling salvos against the Adanis do not necessarily sit well with her party's interests—last year, the group secured the Rs 25,000 crore Tajpur port project in the state. As it is, she was a stormy petrel in a party headed by another stormy petrel, and the passage has had the usual moments of embarrassment. At present, therefore, her future in the Trinamool too hangs in the balance. Asked about the lack of overt backing from her party, Mahua told INDIA TODAY: "I speak for the truth and the truth does not need back-up forces. I will continue my fight." Whether or not the truth endures, it will take all the blessings of her favourite belligerent goddess Kali for her to survive this ad hominem attack. ■

–with M.G. Arun

MAHUA IN THE HOUSE

The Lok Sabha MP from Krishnanagar in West Bengal has been a fierce Opposition presence in the House since 2019. Highlights:

Feb. 9, 2021: Targets an ex-CJI who is now a BJP Rajya Sabha MP, brings up the sexual harassment allegations against him where **"he presided over his own trial, cleared himself.... The sacred cow that was the judiciary is no longer sacred"**

Dec. 13, 2022 Cites government data to show that industrial output was at a 26-month low: **"This government coined the term Pappu. You use it to denigrate and signify extreme incompetence. But the statistics tell us who the actual Pappu is"**

Feb. 8, 2023: Hints at a nexus between PM Modi and businessman Gautam Adani: **"Prime Minister, this man Mr A has fooled (*topi pehnaoed*) you... He travels with you on delegations. He makes it appear to the world that he is the remote control behind the PM and obliging him will oblige the prime minister"**

Aug. 10, 2023: On the continuing violence in Manipur and the refusal to discuss it: **"I don't know what is more unfortunate, our PM refuses to come to Parliament or that he refuses to go to Manipur"**

Sept. 20, 2023: On the delayed implementation of the Women's Reservation Bill: **"Are women less important than cows, since the Centre is building bovine shelters without counting their population, while the Women's Reservation Bill will have to wait for the Census.... This is your moment to show us that Modi *hai toh mumkin hai*"**



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THE BLOWBACK SUGGESTED THERE WERE HOLES IN THE AFFIDAVIT. BY THE TIME DARSHAN CAME ON TV, IT FELT LIKE A RETREAT TO THE BASIC PLAN: GET MAHUA